By Romita Datta

ODISHA'S TRIBAL MARCH

FOR LAND, AND IDENTITY

No strident raising of slogans, no loud banners castigating political opponents, no mainstream media following the marchers. Yet the *padayatra* of around 4,000 tribals from the Oraon, Kisan and Kharia communities, comprising mostly women, kicked up a dust storm as they winded their way through the quiet and picturesque villages of Odisha's Sundargarh district. The *padayatra* covered 80 km to reach the district collector's office in Sundargarh. It's their latest, desperate protest against the Odisha government's planned acquisition of 2,150 acres of agricultural land across five gram panchayats in Sundargarh district's Kutra and Rajgangpur blocks for the expansion of a limestone mining unit of Dalmia Cement Bharat Limited (DCBL). At stake is the looming loss of livelihood, as well as the threat of eviction of thousands of adivasis. In all, 57 villages and nearly 60,000 people might be affected.

The *padayatris*, who battled the heat and the grime of the road for four days, sat on a demonstration in front of the district administrative building for 48 hours, till the sub-collector gave a written assurance that the administration will inform the President of India of their plight, have their allegations examined and stop all acquisition till the matter is resolved. The marchers were given a hero's send-off, with 25 trucks being mobilised to drop them home. Clearly, the administration did not want to risk a mass uprising. Already, 20 panchayats have come together in the protest against the land acquisition for DCBL.

The proposal for the expansion of DCBL's Lanjiberna mines was taken up in 2017. Supposed to be helmed jointly by Odisha Cement Ltd and DCBL, acquisition had been happening surreptitiously from 2018. A public hearing of sorts to settle the matter took place in October 2018, but was inconclusive. Some signatures, numbering not more than 25, were also taken, but landowners alleged the administration had deceived them.

On January 26, 2020, villagers in both blocks decided to register their protest by convening gram sabhas and passing resolutions of not giving an inch of fertile, multi-crop land that yields paddy, lentils, peanuts and flowers. Lila Sushila Toppo, sarpanch of Kukuda panchayat, owner of 14 acres, was livid when told about the government compensation. "I am not interested in money," she says. "I will not give away my ancestral land. It is my identity. And the government notification (in February 2020 and February



ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

WALK FOR LIVELIHOOD
Tribals protesting the land acquisition marching towards Sundargarh